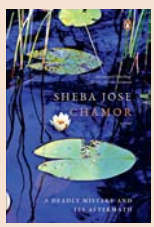
# OPEN BOOK

*A ROUNDUP OF NEWLY RELEASED FICTION*



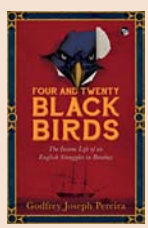

**ADAM**
*by S. Hareesh; translated by Jayasree Kalathil*
VINTAGE
**₹399; 192** pages

In this collection of nine unusual short stories, S. Hareesh, a winner of the JCB Prize for Literature, makes sense of emotions we find hard to contain—lust, anger, envy, vengeance, greed.




**CHAMOR**
*by Sheba Jose*
VINTAGE
**₹599; 312** pages

Seen through the eyes of its young protagonist, *Chamor* and its many events can be both delicate and devastating. Set in a Kerala family plantation, Jose explores childhood as sharply as she does loss.




**FOUR AND TWENTY BLACKBIRDS: The Insane Life of an English Smuggler in Bombay**
*by Godfrey Joseph Pereira*
SPEAKING TIGER
**₹499; 296** pages

This novel tells the story of Charlie Strongbow—a renegade Englishman, mercenary, philosopher and schizophrenic—who embarks on a bizarre journey that will see him win it all but, finally, lose himself.

BOOKS

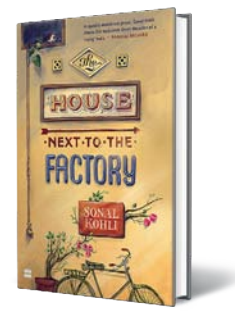
# Capturing India's Many Moods

**Sonali Kohli's** recent collection of short stories encourages us to live more fully and attentively

When all else fails, are we necessarily forced to seek refuge in the inanimate objects encircling us? Does the comfort routine add some personality to our days? American novelist Don DeLillo, in his 1988 novel *Libra*, makes a startling observation—"Some people don't believe in God but they colour eggs at Easter just to change the pattern of their days."

Sonal Kohli's debut collection of short stories is not a study of loneliness, far from it. It is neither an indictment of a country weighed down by its pre-liberalisation era blues, nor a criticism of our plodding ways as a people sceptical of change, of sudden economic shifts, and who fear the stranger. But the people inhabiting these worlds do indeed "colour their Easter eggs".

In '10 Bela Road', we see how the prospect of an ancestral house being sold off doesn't necessarily elicit melodrama from its inhabitants but almost a surrender to the demon that is time. "What if the house knows we are selling it?" ponders the narrator. "I look up, and the house looks back kind of sad." While in 'Other Side of Town', we see how the relationship between two characters (one lovingly named Johnny Walker, the other Rani) goes through multiple gradations—each one finer than the one before. His love for her never quite seems to materialise fully but there is never any resentment from Rani. Kohli is not interested in what messes us up but rather what holds us together along one tight, unbroken seam.




**THE HOUSE NEXT TO THE FACTORY**
*by Sonal Kohli*
FOURTH ESTATE
**₹499; 196 pages**

**SONAL KOHLI IS NOT INTERESTED IN WHAT MESSES US UP, BUT WHAT HOLDS US TOGETHER**

In this collection of nine short stories, one that successfully manages to capture the emotional mood of a nation from the early '70s to nearly the present day, Kohli wields both brevity and ambition to present a simple argument: life is what happens to us when we are most attentive and in sync with the changes threatening the scales on which the living world is balanced.

What gives these nine, slightly interlinked stories a sense of both uneasy calm and acceptance is Kohli's ability to condense the markers of what truly constitutes the human experience in instantly relatable visuals. So, a dog chooses to mark his spot by peeing on mint tea in the night; the sari fabric sticks between a woman's legs while an unbridled desire to hug her first paycheck makes her smile; palms are opened to let fingers slip in as a gesture of safety; and the sweet hint of jasmine wafts through a car as it merges with the sweeter *alaap* of Farida Khanum.

In *The House Next to The Factory*, you will encounter worlds that might be precisely yours, if only you are brave enough to acknowledge their simplicity. Kohli's characters will equally echo in the clang of your kitchen's old brassware on a weekend, the dusty mirror faithfully capturing your family in flux. ■

**–Arman Khan**